

Introduction / Summary

The film “Minority Report” takes place in the future 2054 with the main premise that there is a proposed policing unit called “Pre Crime” which attempts to stop murders before they are able to take place. They do this by receiving premonitions from the three “*precogs*” which were mysteriously able to see into the future and predict murder. This of course was because as a side effect from being on medication and other “practices” to help the *precogs* live longer due to the fact that their parents were addicted to using a new illegal drug which wasn’t in its purest form thus these drug addicts’ children were only expected to live until 12 (not important but I thought this was funny). As a result, the Pre Crime unit was established to interpret these premonitions and stop the murders from taking place and somehow legally detaining the perpetrators despite them not having legally done anything wrong and the pre crime unit not being a voted on legal entity yet. In short, the premise of the film is that predictive policing is used to detain criminals (for what appears like indefinitely with the “John Doe” guy being there for years) before they end up committing crime¹.

How Does Minority Report Conceptualize Technology?

In the film Minority Report technology is the systems used to shape society and the systems that differentiate this society from our own. I think the technology that interested me the most from the movie was the importance of eye scanners (common early 2000’s future tech

¹“Minority Report”

trope) as ID's and the importance of these eye scanners. These scanners were everywhere from subways, special authorized doors, even advertisements which appeared to scan people's eyes then call out the person's name in an attempt to get their attention on their product² (which I think personally would start to make me desensitized to my own name). These eye scanners are a perfect example of Langdon Winner's inherently political technologies because these eye scanners perpetuate notions of a centralized authoritarian structures. In short, inherently political technologies are ones that, regardless of design choices, require a certain political / authority structure and/or enforce said structure through their existence³. The example given by Winner is the idea of an atomic bomb's existence and "lethal properties demand that it be controlled by a centralized, rigidly hierarchical chain of command closed to all influences that might make its workings unpredictable"⁴. Similarly, these eye scanners require a centralized structure or system to sift through and regulate the data not to mention the fact that everyone has their own eye ID technically? This of course runs into the problem of the drug dealer near the start of the movie who was immune to parts of the law simply for the fact that he did not have eyes, which could have been a birth defect or weird accident or even by choice to escape the system which they live in. The more obvious technology from the movie is the *precogs* which are used to predict the future which I believe directly played into the Man and Slave paradigm in Wiener's "Moral and Technical Consequences of Automation". In short, Wiener points out the contradicting nature that a master wants a slave that is more capable

²"Minority Report"

³Winner, Langdon. "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" *Daedalus* 109, no. 1 (Winter 1980): 123.

⁴Winner. "Do Artifacts Have Politics?": 123.

than the other but remains subservient ⁵. In the “Minority Report”, they pumped the *precogs* with sedative drugs at a rate to allow them to be conscious enough to think and foresee the future but not nearly strong enough to move much. This was the Pre Crime units preventative measure to prevent the *precogs* from revolting and thought of as “Not Human”⁶ [explicitly Anderton said its better to think of them as not human] which I think is probably similar to slavery back in the day where masters often didn’t view them as human and didn’t feed them well along with other poor living conditions to prevent them from revolting. The sedatives of course did not prevent the *precogs* from revolting against their creator since with what little conscious Agatha (the strongest *precog*) had she communicated to Anderton asking “Can You See?”⁷ and showing him the killing of Anne Lively who was secretly killed by (and covered up by) Lamar one of the original creators of the *precogs*. Thus, Agatha’s subtle revolt led to Anderton eventually revealing the true death of Anne Lively and exposing Lamar. This is a perfect demonstration to Wiener’s Man and Slave paradigm where there is almost a subtle fearmongering about the inevitable revolt of those enslaved by a master.

Where and How is Ethical Responsibility Questioned?

The first time the ethical responsibility is truly questioned by the main character is when Anderton appears as the perpetrator in the 1109 case despite having no idea who the victim is. As

⁵Wiener, Norbert. “Some Moral and Technical Consequences of Automation.” *Science*, New Series, 131, no. 3410 (May 6, 1960): 1357.

⁶“Minority Report”

⁷“Minority Report”

any movie has it, Anderton then goes on a series of illegal adventures to prove his innocence because he believes this was all a setup and he is being framed. This of course is ironic as Anderton clearly partook in some way the effective kidnapping of over one thousand perpetrators before himself, but because this time he was the perpetrator he was against the system. I think this perfectly relates to the Costanza-Chock reading and talking about the design justice and understanding that the design of technology impacts its community. Specifically looking at the 2nd design principle which is “We center the voices of those who are directly impacted by the outcomes of the design process”⁸. Here Costanza-Chock is arguing that design choices should be centered around those who are actually impacted by the technology. In the movie, it is often centered around the victim, particularly in the brief Pre Crime advertisement, because that perspective is most in favor of the technology. Personally I think there in general would be a bigger disconnect between the victims and perpetrators from this technology because rather than experiencing the crime (thankfully) the victim instead would be approached by some police saying something like “oh someone was gonna kill you but we stopped it your all good now”, which would creep me out if anything. However the advertisement depicted a person saying “He was going to stab me right here”⁹ which I don’t think a victim would necessarily feel that connected to the crime. Although admittedly the first scene of the movie did depict a wife committing adultery then almost being murdered by her husband before Pre Crime stopped him so maybe certain victims did feel attached to their future crimes they were

⁸Costanza-Chock, Sasha. *Design Justice: Community-Led Practices to Build the Worlds We Need*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, (2020): 6.

⁹“Minority Report”

victim too.

When Did Ethical Assumptions and Frameworks Break Down?

I think the underlying philosophical pillar of the Pre Crime unit is the idea of determinism. Essentially, the prime crime unit is contingent on the fact that the perpetrators are determined to commit the crime unless they are stopped. This argument was made at the start of the film when Danny Witwer (the DoJ guy with the warrant who took over the team) questioned the idea of being able to detain people who hadn't committed crimes. John Anderton (the main character) rolled a ball across the table toward Witwer who then caught the ball right before it fell, Anderton argued that the ball was going to fall even though Witwer caught the ball and prevented it from happening¹⁰. However this sort of framework broke at the end of the movie where Lamar was in a vision and was going to kill Anderton for essentially ruining his career and the Pre Crime unit because Anderton publically displayed Lamar killing someone and it going "unnoticed" by the precogs. Despite no external intervention from the Pre Crime unit, Lamar ended up not killing Anderton and instead killed himself which clearly undermines the deterministic/info computationalist perspective of the Pre Crime unit which is crucial to justify the the unit's existence.

¹⁰ "Minority Report"

Works Cited

1. Costanza-Chock, Sasha. *Design Justice: Community-Led Practices to Build the Worlds We Need*. Cambridge, MA: The MIT Press, (2020).
2. "Minority Report"
3. Wiener, Norbert. "Some Moral and Technical Consequences of Automation." *Science*, New Series, 131, no. 3410 (May 6, 1960).
4. Winner, Langdon. "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" *Daedalus* 109, no. 1 (Winter 1980).